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Bill Goodwin

Drummer Bill Goodwin's lengthy career has included a productive relationship with Phil Woods, albums under his own name, and production credits with notable jazz artists.

Bill was interviewed via Zoom on May 28, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to be chatting today with drummer and producer Bill Goodwin. Welcome, sir.

BG: Thank you sir, it's so nice to see you.

MR: Yeah. I'm going to start off with — I debated about trying this actually and I'm going to. It's a fill in the blank.

BG: Okay.

MR: A career in jazz is —

BG: Hopefully long and profitable. A career in jazz is what I dreamed of from when I was about 11 years old, even before I knew what I was dreaming about, and it came together in a strange way. While viewing a movie with my mother, "The Man With the Golden Arm" with Frank Sinatra. If you know the story then you know I don't have to explain it. And it featured — I'd been getting into music, west coast jazz particularly. I had certain favorites and they were all in this movie. At some point there was a big band scene, Sinatra was playing it. Sinatra was a family friend you know. I grew up in Hollywood and my father was in show biz and my mom was too and they were friends of Sinatras who lived in our neighborhood. Well anyway, he had had a hard time going after his big scandal with Ava Gardner. Anyway my mom, she really liked Frank and so she took us to see his movie. And he was very good in it, playing the former junkie drummer who just gets out of jail and decides he wants to be a drummer. It's a Nelson Algren novel, quite, you know like you know Walk on the Wild Side — that guy. So I was struck by the music and seeing, hearing Shelly Manne on the soundtrack and I just thought to myself, my 12-year-old self, I can do that. I could play the drums. I know exactly what he's doing.

MR: You were playing the saxophone at the time, weren't you.

BG: I was playing sax, yeah, but I was never a good sax player. I could play, I could read music and I could play in the school bands, and I continued that through junior high and high school. I played saxophone and I played drums, depending on the situation. But when I went to the first year of high school I was 14, in the ninth grade and I declared

MR: Your father did a lot of announcing and being involved in some comedy shows. Do you recall as a kid hearing his voice on the television? You know doing a Maxwell House commercial or anything like that? What was that experience like?

BG: Well it was actually radio until I was about 10. There really was no commercial TV per se and nobody had television sets, I mean there were very few. And dad was on the radio and he was on every week and was very well known and he would work with either Bob Hope before I was born, and then when I — after he was working with George Burns and Gracie Allen after I was born, and then he went back to work with Bob Hope, you know, when I was around 8 or 9. And I listened all the time. I loved both shows, and the way he worked in the early TV with Burns & Allen too. He was there in just their first season I think with them on television, and then he went back to Bob Hope which was strictly radio, NBC.

MR: You were only around 16 when he passed away, is that correct?

BG: I was 16. Yeah.

MR: Did that occurrence affect your education or your choice to start working? Or what did it do to the family?

BG: It affected everything because my dad proved that you can take it with you, because he left us not penniless but in dire straits. My mom really had to struggle to get back on her feet so we left where we were living — we lived in Palm Springs, California. And we left there and went back to Los Angeles where we had been up until when I started high school. I got to L.A. and just immediately got on the scene there. I didn't finish my last semester of high school and ended up dropping out before graduation. But I was hanging out every night and every day just trying to play, learn to play. I had various fortuitous meetings with some people, young musicians my age or slightly older and they kind of took me in and I already — well to go back a little bit I was already — I already knew Stan Levey and I already knew Mel Lewis where I got to know them pretty quickly by getting back to L.A., and Shelly Manne. And they became like my mentors.

MR: Was there an audition piece — I remember in the early '60s if a drummer could play "Wipe Out" you know like okay you can be in our garage band. Was there something similar to that back then that you would be expected to be able to do?

BG: Yeah to play fast bebop.

MR: Fast bebop.

BG: Yeah. I first met Bobby Hutcherson when Terry Trotter, the pianist, took me over to Bobby's house to play with Bobby and him and Herbie Lewis the bass player. And they were a year older than me. And the first thing Bobby said to me after, "Do you have any marijuana" was, "Can you play fast?" I said, "I don't know, let's find out." So they put

know how to play the drums. I had no technique at all, but I could hear and I could follow music and I could play music in other words, I just didn't have a solid technique on the drums or any technique on the drums.

MR: It's very fortuitous that you just said, "I could play music" because in this particular record in the fine print inside, Phil Woods says, "Bill Goodwin plays the music." He didn't say he plays the drums, he said you play the music.

BG: Well that's true.

MR: Yeah.

BG: I always play the song and I know, most of the songs I play I know them well, I know the lyrics, I know something about the origin and all that, and I love — you know like I love books and music and I like knowing things about them.

MR: What was your reason for coming east?

BG: Gary Burton.

MR: And how does that work? You get a recommendation? Somebody recommends you, you happen to cross paths on Fifth Avenue or how does that thing occur?

BG: I was still living in Los Angeles and it was actually that year that Gary called me to play. I was with George Shearing that year, it was the best paying job in jazz. And you know the guys in the more — let's say less commercial jazz groups were all envious of me and I knew them all, because I made twice as much money as they did, working with George. But I just — you know we didn't get to play real hard, I did a lot of brushes which was good for me. I learned to play the brushes very well I think. Over the '60s I had not hung out with Gary, Steve Swallow, Larry Coryell, Bob Moses. And I liked their music. It was something different. There was only a few — there were only a few what you would call fusion or jazz-rock groups, but Gary's wasn't the only one but it was one of the more successful ones. And you know I always liked going to hear them play whenever I could and I told them, you know if you ever need a drummer, you know try me out. I adore your music and I really love to play with you, which is a process that I recommend to all of my student drummers. Find somebody you like, would want to play with, and let them know. They won't be upset with you.

MR: Oh that's a great one. I had a question down the road, advice to students, and you just nailed it. Do you ever tell them be aware of what bass player you're joining?

BG: Absolutely. Bass players have been my — the people that have pushed me forward the most and the first that I can really remember was Red Mitchell who befriended me when I was about 17, but I already knew some other people, and I was a Jazzbo man. I went to see everybody play. And I got to meet everybody and I was hanging out at the drum shop every day. So I was on the scene and I wanted to be a part of the scene, and I was part of

Levy, the great bebop drummer who befriended me and kind of essentially threatened me to become a better drummer, told me that I wasn't — that I had a lot of possibilities but I wasn't making it technically and I had to practice and get my hands together. And the way he said it, I don't know if you know this about Stan but he was an ex-boxer from Philadelphia. Big guy, very brutal looking guy. He was a sweet man, a wonderful guy, but he looked at you in a way, it was like I'm going to kill you if you don't do what I tell you to do. And I took it to heart. I said Stan — I don't want Stan to kill me. So I got a practice pad and some big practice sticks and started practicing, you know, my ass off. And during that time I was working at, my day job was at NBC in Hollywood, I was a parking lot attendant. And I just — and we didn't have to park cars, we'd just tell people where to go. And so we had the jazz radio on in the office and I had a practice pad with the sticks and I practiced all day at work. And you know I mean as you talk about fortuitous circumstances, you know there's just so many. The one with my sister started dating Terry Trotter the pianist and later they got married. He introduced me to Herbie Lewis and Bobby Hutcherson who were his best pals. And I was meeting all these other people and meanwhile I'm hanging with these guys who were exceptional musicians at their age, just a year older than me, and they really liked me. And they liked me as a friend and I think they liked me as a player. I played with them a lot, up until I started really working more and everybody started leaving town and Bobby moved to New York and Herbie moved to New York and Terry got away from playing jazz, because he married my sister and they had kids.

MR: I see. What about the early rock & roll?

BG: Well rock & roll was happening, started happening when I already loved west coast jazz. And you know Elvis's first records came out. But I used to listen to a lot of rhythm & blues you know, Fats Domino and Chuck Berry, Bo Diddley, and the blues, the Howlin' Wolf and Muddy Waters and all those guys. And they put out singles but they were considered race records. It hadn't crossed over at that point, until later. And I loved that stuff, and I thought Elvis was — I said Elvis is very good. I really liked him, but he was kind of a shadow of those guys. You know he wasn't — and he even said that you know. It was pretty obvious that he was indebted to all those real, you know southern blues singers and rhythm & blues singers. And then I started buying those records. But I didn't — I never really bought Elvis's records. He was on the radio a lot and I liked some of his stuff. Some of it was very funny too because it was parodied by guys like Stan Freberg — do you know who that was?

MR: Yes.

BG: Stan Freberg does a take-off on "Heartbreak Hotel." He did take-offs on a lot of people.

much echo — echo-echo-echo-echo-echo-echo. And it's like that little spring echo saying [makes a noise of a spring].

MR: And that pre-dated "more cowbell."

BG: Oh absolutely, by three decades.

MR: Did you reach a point as a young man that you could make a living, live on your own by playing the drums? When did that occur?

BG: I figured out that it was possible, and that's what I wanted to do. So I had this day job at NBC, which my mom would help me get, and I was happy working there. And you know if you join NBC at a lesser capacity, like the mail room or the parking lot, you essentially would be in the organization and then they — when they found a place they'd maybe move you up to something more, you know better in the business. And my dad had worked for NBC for years so you know I got hired because the president of NBC told them to hire me, because he was friends with my mom. So I didn't want to do that. I wanted to do the job but I wanted to hang out and play at night, and it went well as far as that goes, but then I got a chance to do an actual record date, rehearsing for a week and then recording — a real professional recording session, not just a home taping or anything. And I wanted to do it and they wouldn't let me off to do it so I quit. And my mom was a little alarmed.

MR: You know Eddie Bert had a fantastic story.

BG: I thought I'd be able to make it, I think I'm going to be okay. By that time I was 19, was already getting calls to play with a lot of people, was playing with really bass players like Red, and Gary Peacock was a friend and he really liked my playing 'cause I was more adventurous than the people he played with. And he was, you know what happened to him?

MR: Can you define "adventurous" at that point in the west coast jazz scene?

BG: Ornette Coleman's first record came out, the second record came out while I was still in high school, and I loved them, I bought them and I loved them. The reason I bought them was they were on Contemporary Records which was my favorite label, and I had already got to meet and, you know as a teenager gotten to meet and play with Art Pepper and I listened to "Shelly Manne and His Men" were on that label and I loved everything on Contemporary Records. I would just get it, and I saw Ornette Coleman on the album with his plastic saxophone and said, "Who's this guy?" You know, had to check it out, and I just fell in love with his music. And so that was where Gary was in that camp, and we played a lot with Dennis Budimir, he's a great guitarist and we often worked with Bud Shank who had a regular night at Shelly's Manne-Hole, like an off night, a weeknight.

MR: Now those guys followed the path into the studios and I'm assuming they made a pretty

BG: Well Bud was already there. Dennis went there. Dennis Budimir, I don't know if you know him, was a marvelous guitar player. Extremely creative. And was an influence on Bill Frisell, according to Bill anyway, Bill told me that. We made some records, home recordings that later came out and Bill being much younger than us he had heard them when he was young and he told me once he was extremely influenced by Dennis and those records, which was nice to hear you know. And so what happened — oh it's still a blur — so much was going on and L.A. was just rife with things to do. Lots of gigs, lots of jam sessions, lots of rehearsals. So you know I started making my way but at 19 I got hired by Terry Gibbs to play with him, you know, Hollywood on Sunset Strip, The Crescendo. And The Crescendo was owned by Gene Norman who had a late night radio show in L.A. and played jazz, and he also had the Gene Norman Presents label and he had put out the "Dizzy Gillespie at the Shrine Auditorium," a big band record which I loved, and he put out the first Clifford Brown/Max Roach record which I loved. And he was like my dad, a famous, at least locally, radio voice, and a wonderful voice. And of course I'd meet these people later on in life and they'd all say what an influence my father was on them, it was pretty nice to have that association. But it was really my sister and my mother who I think were more instrumental in my career. So my dad would take me out to hear music and stuff and he knew everybody. So you know within five minutes of coming to a club, you know we'd be sitting with the band.

MR: I love that, sitting with the band. I have it from an inside source that you used to be known as the "bebop newspaper."

BG: Oh where'd you hear that? It was started as a — I think it was — I don't know it could have been Dick Wittington my piano player friend, another part of our clique, Dick, or it was a piano player named Marty Harris that I played with a lot too and he used to call me, Dick called me the "bebop Walter Winchell."

MR: Oh. Well an acquaintance named Art Bailey gave me that little inside scoop.

BG: Well yeah, that's cool. I bet I told Art that.

MR: Yes, I think you did. Did you have — did your goals change as things went along? Because you went to the other end of the country to play with Gary Burton, or I'm not sure I'm correct about that but you relocated, is that correct?

BG: I did.

MR: Yeah. And then after a few years you went to the Poconos.

BG: After a year.

MR: Was that a financial decision? An artistic decision?

BG: More of a lifestyle decision. We had lived in California, I grew up there. I lived in my old neighborhood and we had a house. And we got to New York and we didn't have a house

friends and all of that. But then we got to be, you know I was doing well on the gig and I knew we were going to hang for a while and came out to visit a friend that I had already made in Los Angeles, who I'm sure you knew about, Bob Dorough, the singer-songwriter.

MR: Yes.

BG: And producer. And Bob and I had worked in L.A. together backing up a folk singer named Chad Mitchell. And so we had become really good friends and also his partner in that was a guitarist named Stuart Scharf, and we all became very, very close friends. And Bob was like an older brother to me. A little like a mentor as much as a guy who just really liked me, we got along great and they started hiring me and all that stuff — when I wasn't on the road with Gary. And I came to visit him in Pennsylvania in the Poconos — I'm hiccoughing for some reason, excuse me. And we just loved it. So a year after we moved to New York almost exactly to the year January of 1970 we moved out to the Poconos and I basically have had a place out here since then. It's like 55 years.

MR: What was a typical gig in the Poconos like at that time?

BG: A typical?

MR: A typical gig.

BG: A gig? Well I wasn't working in the Poconos really much. I would work some local gigs occasionally and they were pretty lame. But then I got in, through Bob I met musicians who had decamped to Pennsylvania. There was Jay Cameron the baritone sax player, owned a music store on Main Street in Stroudsburg, and Bob Newman, the saxophonist from Philadelphia was the band leader at a resort. So I met those guys and we started jamming and playing together but mostly I was playing with Gary and then traveling. And the last year with Gary was probably '69, '70, 1971. And our business had just fallen apart. Rock took over and they didn't — we used to play colleges and all of a sudden we weren't playing colleges anymore. They spent all the money on one band for homecoming instead of five bands.

MR: I know exactly what you're talking about because I was in college right around that time and yeah, the scene for jazz was great in colleges and then it wasn't.

BG: It was the first record that I bought for myself was Dave Brubeck "Jazz Goes to College."

MR: So the next step after Gary Burton, did your calendar get filled up like in a hurry?

BG: Oh I was doing commercial work in New York, you know gigs and recordings, and working on the "Schoolhouse Rock" series with Bob and sometimes I played on, well the great preponderance of those tracks are me on drums.

MR: The great what?

BG: Preponderance.

MR: Oh yeah. I'm on most of them. Been into like a wordy phase lately. Using bigger words, I don't know why. It's a synoli of some kind. But yeah with doing that, and I was doing quite a bit of other recordings, some jazz recordings, and I played a lot with — well I played at the Mount Airy Lodge with Bob Newman's band for a year, after I left Gary, and that's where I met Steve Gilmore who later was the bass player with Phil. I introduced them. So I loved playing with Steve, and we had a really great band at Mount Airy Lodge, we played you know all kinds of music, we had a lot of rock and rhythm & blues and dance music. We also played jazz and we had jazz players in the band and we'd have jam sessions and we'd back up some big acts, you know people tried to hire me out of there, but me and Steve together because we were a very good team. We could play just about any style of anything.

MR: Was he playing electric bass?

BG: He would from time to time.

MR: Yeah.

BG: He played the stand-up bass mostly but then he had the electric and he could play it very well.

MR: What's your preference?

BG: My preference?

MR: As far as —

BG: A good bass player. They could be playing a washtub —

MR: It doesn't matter what he's playing. Okay what makes a good bass player?

BG: Well a beautiful time feeling that can negotiate the odd sensation of playing with me I think.

MR: Can you —

BG: Somebody you can groove with. You know it's nice to really work with some bass players. I could always play easily with Gary Peacock, Red Mitchell. We had to work at it for a while but we stuck with it and eventually became very good together. Then I fortuitously moved across the street from Leroy Vinnegar in the Hollywood Hills and he befriended me and then I played with his group. So I was always playing with really good bass players or as much as I could. But after I played with Leroy it's like I could get that feeling without — the feeling I got with him I could get with other bass players, which is saying something because you know he was just such a rock, man, a wonderful beat. That's always been the thing for me is the beat, the way the bass and drums combine, you know to me that's like the beautiful part of the music. That feeling is very energizing.

MR: Is there such a thing as playing on top of the beat or behind the beat without changing the tempo?

MR: The big beat. Yeah. But I'd like you —

BG: About the beat, it's not like this, it's like this, right? So the bigger it is the more you can subdivide and put stuff in there, but it starts before the beat and it ends after the beat. Does that make sense? It's like you breathe 1-2-3-4, [different emphasis] uh 1, uh 2, uh 3, uh uh uh uh uh. So it's like the upbeat to the downbeat — you know I was soaking up the influences I found, the drummers that I really, really liked and I would, well frankly emulate them and steal their stuff if I could. You know you really can't you know. I mean I could play all of Roy Haynes's licks but I'd never sound like Roy. But if I saw Roy or Art Blakey or any of those guys in later life when I got to know them and I would quote their licks to them they just loved it. It became like a funny thing that I liked to do and it's my whole — it's pretty nutty man, the humor.

MR: Well your students probably would do the same thing with you.

BG: Most of them are too young to even know my oeuvre so to speak, or you know they knew about me and I was on the faculty of a jazz school so I was certainly well known but I wasn't like, you know Jack DeJohnette or, you know, Tony Williams 'cause they were all — I think that, I remember first teaching in the College of William Paterson and I asked somebody who their favorite older drummer was and they said Tony Williams. I said, "Tony Williams, that young guy?" He's like four years younger than me." I said, "He's not an old master yet." You know these are people that think that jazz started with John Coltrane.

MR: Yes.

BG: That's pretty normal.

MR: Or Michael Brecker now.

BG: [Inaudible] The things that led up to that — as Max Roach pointed out years ago when he was being complimented for his innovations on the drums, he said, "I'm just standing on the shoulders of those who came before." And I firmly believe that. And I've tried to pass that on and hopefully they get it. These guys have like so much ability on the drums at their age and they're like teenagers, like I was. They're in school but they can really play the drums, you know, whereas I had to learn to play the drums when I was already a professional musician.

MR: Do you have words of advice for them as they graduate and try to make their way in the business?

BG: Well I tell them if you could do something else it's probably a good idea to do it, and then play for fun. Because I — the business as such is nothing like it was when I started out. I can't really advise them too much about what's happening today. Though I do know the process of getting involved in music and becoming a player and a known player

Probably not money or fame but that you just love the music as I did, and you find a way to do it. But most all my students, if they're not full time musicians they're doing something, they're teaching, they start their own labels, they, you know there's so many different things that they can do. So they just paid a lot of money to go to college for four years and they end up with a degree in jazz performance and I say, "What are you going to do with that? You can go down to Small's and show them your document? "Can I sit in you know here's my B.F.A." And they think it's funny but I'm sort of not kidding.

MR: Right. Probably mom and dad are asking the same question.

BG: You've got to go play. You've got to meet people.

MR: So let me talk about, ask you about producing a little bit.

BG: Sure.

MR: Did you get into it — I'll just say "on purpose." How did it occur?

BG: Well it happened because I joined Phil Woods's band or we joined it was really like a cooperative band. For some reason we played really well together in the original quartet. And Phil had his manager at that time who was also his record producer. And the guy was an accountant and he knew nothing about music. But he'd still tell you how to play. And I had been thinking about it, to say if that guy can do that I could do that gig and I could make ten times what I'm making on this record date, like he is. I was making a hundred bucks, he'd be making a thousand bucks. So I said well I could do better than him.

MR: Who is paying him?

BG: I wasn't an audiophile but I really knew how records were made. I'd been hanging out in the studio since I was a teenager and hearing these great musicians and I was no stranger to that part of the business as far as being a musician. But the producer was quite often not really very musically inclined in a way. They were businessmen, I mean they got classic guys, you know the Bob Thiele and the Ertugen brothers and so forth, Lester Koenig was a great model for me from Contemporary Records. And I had befriended him because of my friendship with — or he befriended me because of my friendship with Art Pepper. It was at — I used to go to Contemporary Studios and witness recording sessions. I remember taking Art to a session he was doing with Marty Paich, it was called "The Great Jazz Standards" or something like that, it was about a ten piece band. Wonderful record. Art plays the tenor, alto, and clarinet on it. And Marty's arrangements — marvelous.

MR: I bet you were soaking it all in.

BG: I was. Soaking it all in, you know like the fly on the wall, a very big fly on the wall.

MR: Orrin Keepnews — I asked him if he had a definition or a philosophy about producing and he said, he described it as being a catalytic agent creating a circumstance where an artist can work most effectively.

BG: That's a good way of putting it. But you know what it really boiled down to me was being able to relate to the musicians and to the business of music. See for a long time I didn't relate to music as a business. I just did it and I made money at it. I wasn't that aware of the greater music business. But then when we were working with this producer with Phil and then they had a big falling out because it turns out the guy was padding the budgets and keeping the money. He was basically stealing. And he's dead now so I won't defame him any further than necessary.

MR: Yeah because you mentioned he might be making ten times more than the musicians and I'm wondering who's paying the producer? Is it the record label?

BG: Well we were on RCA Records so he was getting big budgets for us and he was spending only half of the money and keeping the rest.

MR: So now you're in the producer's —

BG: The producer found out and got rid of him.

MR: Yeah. So now you're in the producer's chair and you are dealing with the budget.

BG: It didn't happen overnight. I used to get friends together to record, we had friends in the studios that you know, had engineer friends and stuff and be able to get into the studio after midnight and record for free and then do things on spec and things like that, and I started taking more control over that. And I just got to know it better but then when Phil's producer was no longer a producer I had been recording our group when we were on the road. I had recorded several hours of performance at the venue in Austin, Texas called the Armadillo World Headquarters. Great venue, and mostly like rock and western swing and country music, you know, Texas music. But they had jazz groups there. We had a great booking agent. He would book us in places like that. And they loved us there. And they had a recording studio behind the stage and I recorded the band for, you know, twice I think in subsequent years, maybe '78, '79. And I had these tapes, they were beautiful, beautiful-sounding tapes. The guys were wonderful engineers, direct to two track live recording which became kind of my trademark. It was, you know, old school recording, which is, I am from that school.

MR: No overdubbing allowed.

BG: Well we had them but we had been dropped by RCA. We did not have a record deal. I had the tapes and somehow word got around about them and these two small labels, one was in Baltimore, one was in Washington. They called me and they wanted to do a thing with two albums, that I had enough material for two LPs. So they split it up. One took

they were called. They were the first records that I got production credit on. And you know we went from making — you know I was able to negotiate you know a fairly nice budget for those. They were already recorded and I hadn't spent a lot of money recording them so I was able to get probably a total of maybe 15 grand for both of them and then the next thing that happened was Ron Goldstein from Island Records called me because I had met him when he was with Warner Brothers Records. And he was starting out as president of an Island subsidiary, an Island subsidiary called Antilles Records, which sounds like your "Aunt Tilly" but it was Antilles. Like the Lesser Antilles.

MR: Yeah.

BG: And we had talked about — he liked us but he couldn't sign us to Warner Brothers. But in any case he called me and he said, "What are you doing, what's happening with the group?" I said, "Well we're available." He said, "Well I want to sign you guys for a couple of records." So he did and those paid, the first one paid $13,500 and the second was $15,000. So I negotiated that. And then the guys in the group started to think maybe Bill really knows how to produce records. Actually I had the gift of gab man. I could like go in and got to know these people and I started hanging with these people. I got to know presidents of record companies and you know agents and promoters and all of that, and I was an active player. And I was producing one of the great jazz groups, which I happened to be the drummer in. Another fortuitous circumstance.

MR: Do you think your — how do I describe — what you listened for changed as your role expanded?

BG: What I listened for? No my values stayed the same. And they were established very early in my listening habits. I like mono and simple stereo recording. The multi-track recording I have no problem with it. Digital recording I have no problem with it. But all I'm really interested in is what ends up on those two tracks.

MR: Did you ever have any disagreements with engineers?

BG: Not much. Occasionally. I'm pretty direct about what I want to do. I had like really good engineers that liked my playing, you know I had worked a lot with Jim Anderson, the great engineer that recently is teaching at NYU, the Tisch School. In fact he started their own recording program there 25 years ago or something and he was the engineer for "Jazz Alive" which was based in DC. And they recorded Phil's group live several times and I really liked what he did and I liked him. We became friends and I had a friend in Pennsylvania that ran a little — was the engineer at a little studio called Mountain Sound. His name was Christopher Vescera. Chris Vescera. And he eventually moved out west and he's still out there. He's been out west for 40 years now but in the beginning he helped me put together those two LPs. Because I had the tapes but you know I needed

what you do so much because people think they know things and most of them don't. But you know, you have to use my understanding of the music and the technology in editing and so forth. You know we used to cut tape with a razor blade.

MR: I recall the first time I saw that I was stunned that such a thing was possible.

BG: You didn't know?

MR: I didn't know until I first did a session or something and I saw the engineer do it and then put it back together and like wow. I remember he used to listen, he would turn the reels and he'd listen for the bass drum [scats] to hit the spot.

BG: Yeah. Well I got really good at that. Both those guys were great but I also worked with — well you work with any engineer who is competent and there are plenty of those.

MR: Did you like to see the bass being recorded in a certain fashion? The acoustic bass?

BG: Well yeah. Like you know several different things. One would be just stereo, a pair of mics. This is the way Manfred Eicher did everything with, you know everything in stereo. Two mics on each horn, two mics on the bass, and then more mics on the drums of course. And I had seen him do that in the studio. And let me see now. I like, you know I like the natural sound of the bass. Not all basses sound the same. Not all bass players hear their bass in the same way that I do either. For example when I was doing a Tom Harrell record I had hired Charlie Haden for it. Charlie loved to dominate the sound. And so the record came out, a very nice record. And I ran into him in some club somewhere and I said, "Did you hear the record?" He said, "Yeah. The bass isn't loud enough." I said, "Listen man, this here is not your record, it's Tom's record, and I can hear every note you're playing. Because Charlie couldn't really read and he was really roughing it off there quite a bit.

MR: I remember.

BG: It might have helped. The music was fine. There was one called "Form." It was also on Contemporary Records as a matter of fact. It was owned by Fantasy at that point. And I got to record a bunch of Tom's records for them and then later the Chesky Brothers, Chesky Records with Tom. But you know Paul Motian and Danilo Perez — early recording of Danilo — he wasn't even 21 yet.

MR: Oh my.

BG: Yeah he was pretty great, man. I just loved that guy.

MR: Do you have memories of — I've got different categories here: Best gig ever? Worst gig ever? Most bizarre circumstance getting to a gig and getting home? That kind of thing?

BG: Yeah but mostly I can't remember that stuff.

MR: I know what you mean.

BG: Either it has to do with alcohol and drugs possibly or you know bad intentions. So I don't

things that happened. Like when I was playing with Gerry Mulligan in a club in New York. I worked with Gerry for a couple of years you know after Gary's group broke up you know I played a lot with Gerry. I played with Al Cohn and Zoot Sims, with Stan Getz for a little while. You know I was playing a lot of gigs. And Bobby Hackett. You know gigs in New York mostly, sometimes on the road like Chicago or someplace. I think I went to Detroit with Stan, Chicago. Oh I was touring. A lot of work with Mose Allison. We had recorded in L.A. with Red Mitchell on bass and he really liked my playing so when I moved back east we hooked up and I did a lot of gigs with him. So I was working you know, quite a bit, and all with people that I liked. And I remember some funny things. Like after not playing with Mose for a decade and he called me to do some gigs and I went down to Philly to do a gig with him. And the first set he played of tunes we had recorded and I remembered them all so it was good, you know it really sounded good. Because you know he didn't rehearse. So the second set I couldn't find one. It was just — I had no idea what was going on. It was all new music. Afterwards Mose did a thing which he never used to do which is he took me, he says, "Lets go to the bar and have a beer." You know he would usually just pay you and leave you know, he didn't hang out really. For some reason he took pity on me saying, "I see you were having trouble there on the second set." I said, "Yeah man, what the hell was going on?" He said, "I probably should have told you about my new concept. I call it 'anti-time.'" I said, "Yeah you probably should have told me." But we remained good friends and I did play with him more later but at one point in the '70s we played all the time, all over the place. And we did a monstrous opening for Bonnie Raitt which was really great and I got to know her and her guys in her band. And then Bonnie and her band introduced me to Tom Waits, the person and the idea, and he hired me to do his record with "Nighthawks at the Diner." So I flew back to L.A. to do that with all my L.A. buddies, Jim Hughart on bass, Mike Melvoin on piano and Pete Christlieb on tenor. So it was like, you know, he didn't know any of that. But his producer, Bones Howe knew me because we were friends and Bones is also a friend of Bob DeRosa and Leroy Vinnegar's. So I followed them actually. I heard Tom Waits. I just loved what he was doing. It was wonderful. So I called Bones, I knew he was the producer. I said, "I just met Tom Waits and I don't know, I just had this feeling — he told me he's going to record soon and I have a feeling I'd be good for the record." He said, "That's funny because he just told me the same thing earlier today."

MR: Oh that's really nice.

BG: So he called up to say he would get me on the record because he heard me with Mose and he really liked my playing.

BG: So that was that. You know —

MR: Did Bones Howe pass away?

BG: Huh?

MR: Did Bones Howe — he passed away, didn't he?

BG: I don't know.

MR: I was trying to track him down because —

BG: Could be.

MR: I saw his name on a lot of things, Fifth Dimension and all kinds of stuff.

BG: Well yeah, he became a producer, a very good producer. He was a great engineer. He engineered the first Ornette Coleman records on Atlantic Records, the ones they did in L.A. He did two for Contemporary, then he did two for Atlantic and Bones engineered the Atlantic ones. And he was a great guy, also a very good drummer.

MR: Have you been in a situation as a producer, this might be more of a pop thing where you had to really hype somebody up to get in there, "You can do it, you can do it."?

BG: Well occasionally, mostly some really old guy who is out of his gourd I think without defaming him I think there was a session I did pretty early on in the '70s in my producing career or early '80s. Early 80's I guess, was Phil Woods and Lew Tabackin. And the rhythm section was me and Michael Moore on bass and Jimmy Rowles on piano. And Jimmy had taken the — had left home in L.A. and moved in to New York and was living with Carol Sloane the singer and had gone on the road — had taken the gig with Ella Fitzgerald. So he was traveling with Ella and I called Carol to see if Jimmy would be able to do the date we had in New York and it turned out to be fine but he had really just gotten back. So he shows up and he's half lit and, you know, here Phil and I are walking down the street and there's Jimmy with some police. He's pointing at us. He's looking for the studio and he can't find it. And he's pointing at me and Phil going, "Those is that, that's them." And we go like, "Oh shit, you know, are we going to get busted now?" But no, it was fine. But he kept trying to resign from the date, you know, he was tired. He played beautifully but he actually played — we played one tune without him because we finally just had to let him go and one had chemical means of keeping him awake and we used that until it didn't work anymore.

MR: I've often wondered about that. Sometimes you see a record where it's a quartet except for one song that's a trio. Like no chordal instrument. And you think, "Oh that was very experimental for them" when in fact probably the piano player just couldn't finish.

BG: Or really more esperential. Yeah it happens. Those are scenes where you get prepared to do a recording. I like to do live recordings a lot and there was one we were going to do in New York at a club with Phil and I had it all set up. We had a really great relationship

friendly over the years and I wanted to do a — we had done — I'd done some records for Bruce for Blue Note but I hadn't done Phil's group. I said you know we could do something with Phil. And he said that maybe that was a good idea but he didn't know. So then we were going to do a thing at this club in New York called The Iridium and we were going to have the quintet with Brian Lynch, Phil, and Bill Charlap, Steve Gilmore and myself. We had a guest, Bob Dorough and Jon Gordon the alto player, the young alto player. And so we were doing this gig and Bruce was coming down every night to hear it. He still hadn't given us the deal but he was coming every night to hear it, I know he was thinking about it, thinking deeply about it probably. And then we were getting ready — the day we were going to record Phil decided he didn't want to do it. And he didn't have a good reason but you know it was Phil Woods' record, what are you going to do if he didn't want to do it? He had a dispute with the club. See here's the thing with Phil was he could be a real loose cannon sometimes. And you know he didn't have much of the slightest idea about what I did you know.

MR: I see.

BG: And I preferred that, you think that maybe he was more, you know, important than he really was in that regard. I see no reason to not, plus he was my brother-in-law at that point so. [inaudible] with Phil, you know I'd never met him, I'd seem him play and stood next to him at the Newport festival, but I'd never met him. And all of a sudden he comes to my house and lives with me for two months with my sister. And that's when we started the group. People go, "How'd you hook up with Phil?" I said, "Well he showed up at my front door and I opened the door, I said, "Hi, I'm Bill." He said, "Hi, I'm Phil." And then you know three months later we started the band.

MR: I had a nice chat with him at the Deer Head Inn years ago. It was real fun for me. For one thing he had a good Cannonball Adderley story and all kinds of things like that.

BG: Oh yeah. Oh you know I knew Cannonball, he was a great man. A wonderful man.

MR: Among the other people that I was going to ask you about was Joe Williams.

BG: Oh yeah.

MR: Because he helped get this project started years ago and was a very dear friend.

BG: No, I thought that — did he go to college there or is from the college?

MR: No he did not. He befriended a fella named Milt Fillius who did go to college here, class of '44, and Milt Fillius was a tremendous jazz fan and supporter, almost like a patron. He got to know Joe and so around 1993 they decided that too many musicians were passing away without getting their stories told. And so we started this project and Joe lent his reputation to it. He did some interviewing for us and he received an honorary degree from Hamilton College and —

BG: Another beautiful person. I got to work with him for a few weeks in the '60s and he wanted a trio with Jim Hughart and Mike Melvoin and I and we went up to Seattle and played and did some radio up there which was later released as half of an LP. But anyway Joe loved the trio and we loved him. He was so great once we settled in together after a few nights man I just felt like going home every night. And he was so great that he — I would see him after that and he would always tell people that he really loved my playing and that I'd play things in his charts that weren't written in there that he had written in there because he liked them so much. You know just little things. You know question and answer type stuff. But man what a beautiful cat, and what a great artist. So much fun to play with him. And it, you know like a lot of great people sharing also with this magnificent artist. I played, you know I loved playing with him and I would have stayed with him if Gary hadn't called, except I had gotten an inquiry from Kenny Drew in Copenhagen but — through Red Mitchell about me coming there to play with him and Neils-Pederson. So I had these two — you know what should I do? Move to New York? Go to Copenhagen? Well I'd never been to Europe at that point though Red had already moved, Mitchell, and that's why he recommended me. And so I took, and I always wanted to move to New York. New York, if you were in L.A. you knew about New York, play the big game, get validated. I got over that pretty quick. But I don't regret it. Don't regret it at all.

MR: Yeah.

BG: I'm here because — speaking of bass players — because of Steve Swallow. He just kept mentioning my name to Gary because Steve and I were friends and he said, "You know Bill Goodwin would really like to do this gig, he's often said that to me." So Gary called me up and says, "Swallow keeps mentioning that we're looking for a new drummer. Roy Haynes is leaving the group, would you like to audition for the gig?" I said, "Yeah I would, man, it'd be great." So he sends me a ticket and I fly back to New York and we go to his house on Long Island, Swallow comes out on the train and we play one tune, and the tune was "Falling Grace," which I had never heard before in my life.

MR: You had not heard it.

BG: I'd never heard it. And so I played it and I guess they liked it 'cause I played one tune on the audition and then we played another one for fun and I got hired.

MR: That's very interesting 'cause I just listened to it this morning because I knew that was part of your story. And when I was listening to it —

BG: How do you learn these things, Monk?

MR: But I was listening to it thinking of how that was for you and I can imagine it was a challenge.

MR: Well I thought it was.

BG: It was what it was supposed to be. You know to me it was like well I'm here and I'm going to get this gig you know.

MR: That's a good attitude.

BG: Well I pretty much always had that — there have been instances where I was pretty sure I wasn't going to do so well and I would turn the gig down with that. Sorry that I did now. One was to play the Leonard Bernstein mass and that was because of Chuck Israels, another bass player, was always recommending me for stuff. And so it is what it is. I knew that, you know it was just kismet, you know? And the phone rings and you know I've had so many offers. You know, say really good paying, good gig offers that I had to turn down because of joining Phil's group and right at the same time Marty Morell left Bill Evans and Bill called me. I was the first drummer he called and I went and played with him for about ten days. He offered me the gig and I turned it down.

MR: You know Steve Gilmore said that he thinks he missed some work because people thought oh well he plays with Phil Woods. He's not going to be able to do anything else.

BG: Well Steve was very busy before he was working with Phil doing Broadway shows, subbing and playing with a lot of people. And he, you know, it could be, but I just had to make that choice. Because I'd always wanted to play with Bill Evans. That was a band that was — traveled all the time. And that's what we were getting into with Phil, and you know that was a band that nobody knew really. We started to get well known, we started to get gigs, and it was something like, you know you'd get an opportunity to start something from, you know square one and make it happen, you know it turned out to be 40 years. I mean that's pretty good man. But I turned down — let's see — the only guy that I turned down, Bill Evans, Horace Silver, and Herb Alpert and the Tijuana Brass.

MR: Is that right?

BG: Absolutely.

MR: The touring band?

BG: Yeah. They were all my friends.

MR: That's so interesting.

BG: They recommended me and I went and auditioned for Herb Alpert. He said, "Well you can have the gig, you can certainly do the gig but I want you to move back to L.A." I said, "No, man, I'm not going to do that."

MR: Well from Herb Alpert to — Yeah, all these people. It's amazing. One last thing and I don't know if I can formulate this question so that you could try to answer it. Does jazz have a role in society now? I feel like it used to and I'm wondering if it still does in your opinion?

BG: I was going to ask you what you think, but I think that as long as people love that music they're going to want to play it. It's not about the bread or any of that. I mean there's plenty of opportunities in commercial music to play good music. But to play jazz, especially the stuff that I like which is straight ahead jazz, you know bebop essentially, but you know I don't just play bop but we played good bebop with Phil and that was fantastic for me. I knew all the repertoire, and then we got to record and tour with Dizzy Gillespie with the quintet, it was the highlight of my life you know, because Dizzy had been my idol since I was about 13, one of the main idols and so to get to know him and to work with him was great and to have the friendships with all these great players went beyond playing together but it involved playing together, it involved knowing each other, hanging out and doing fun things. I wish I could remember more of it. I think it will always be there man, I really do. Because as long as people want to play it, we'll play it for fun, for ourselves. We'll get together and play. I play one night a week at the Deer Head Inn, you know, it's a jazz outpost that's become more well known, especially because of the Keith Jarrett recordings, which I produced by the way.

MR: I'll close with sort of what you're talking about. A quote from Phil Woods. He says, "Some couple comes up and says, 'We were married to 'Round Trip' or your music means so much,' those kinds of comments. Believe me, I'm honored to get prizes and all that, but to have the music mean something to people on that level you can't buy that man, it ain't for sale."

BG: I agree completely. You know when you're on the bandstand you're playing sincerely it's almost like you establish a covenant with the audience where you're all in it together. And I was as much involved in that, I'm part of the circle, they're part of the circle, we're all there together for the, you know if not the same reasons we're all there together, involved in the same thing. And if you get approval from that, you know it's good. You're going to do it anyway but it just makes it better when you're enjoying it with other people and, well you know it's a social music. It's a dance form. It's the thing that people forget now I think, a lot of the young people. You know you're supposed to be able to dance to this, even if it's a weird sort of dance. It should move you to — it should inspire you to want to move. And you know — so I know I like something, I start involuntary movement.

MR: Well said.

BG: Do a lot of this — this kind of thing.

MR: And you've developed a sense of humor over the years as well.

BG: Oh I'd say, yeah.

MR: Well thanks for your time today, Bill. It's been marvelous.

MR: All right. I'll pause here and we'll have our good-byes.

BG: Okay it's nice to be in your archive.